that there was a Greater China comprising several ethnic groups, and therefore these groups should also be accepted as Chinese. In a memorial to the Qing monarchy, he said:

> Because the Manchus, Han-Chinese, Mongols, Muslims and Tibetans all belong to a single state, they are all Chinese (Zhongguoren) without any distinctions. [3]

This was an effort to foster greater Chinese nationalism, as against Han nationalism of the variety represented by Sun Yat-sen, who attacked the Qing as ‘alien’ and oppressive.

Other Chinese scholars go back into history to argue that China has been a multi-ethnic state during important periods of its history. The scholar He Pingti cites the example of the Tang dynasty ruling over a multi-ethnic empire. He argues that the vassals of the empire were willing subjects sharing a ‘rare sense of mutual belonging’ with the Tang emperor. He fails to acknowledge the fact that this was a hierarchical relationship, where Sinicization meant imposing a homogeneity based on Han cultural values and precepts over diverse ethnicities, which were implicitly less civilized. Willing submission to the Han by erasing their own distinctive identity was the condition for the non-Han to feel a ‘sense of mutual belonging’ that He Pingti speaks about.

The legitimacy of modern China’s claim over the vast territories of Tibet, Xinjiang and Mongolia hinges on whether the Qing rulers treated these conquests as expanding their Chinese empire or considered these territories as separate and distinct entities within the empire with the same status as the Chinese territory inherited from the Ming dynasty. China argues that the Qing indeed considered themselves as a Chinese political entity, observing traditional and Confucian political norms and rituals, and added their conquests in Inner Asia to China. Furthermore, the various ethnic groups incorporated in the empire were to be treated as Chinese by virtue of their having been part of a Chinese empire. Their separate identities do not bestow on them the right to independent or even autonomous existence. Their future lies in becoming Sinicized members of the Chinese family. It is against this backdrop that we should examine the current policies of China in Tibet and Xinjiang involving the systematic erasure of local languages,